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AIPAC enters Democratic primary wielding unprecedented $4.5 million against candidate

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WASHINGTON – AIPAC's United Democracy Project Super PAC is joining its first significant race in the 2024 election cycle, spending more than $4.5 million as of February 28 to target Dave Min in a Democratic primary to replace Rep. Katie Porter in California.

The figure is the most AIPAC has ever spent against a candidate in its short history, exceeding previous highs against Donna Edwards (whom it successfully helped defeat in Maryland in 2022 with $4.2 million in attacks) and Rep. Summer Lee (who won despite United Democracy Project's $3.2 million in attack ads against her).

Min is running against political activist Joanna Weiss in the primary for the Orange County seat which is set to take place this coming Tuesday. Republicans consider the race a prime pick-up opportunity after Porter opted to run for Senate.

The ads – like the vast majority of the attack ads it funded in the 2022 election cycle – do not focus on Israel but instead showcase the California state senator's 2023 DUI arrest.

"Dave Min wants your trust, but Min was arrested for drunk driving, putting us all at risk. Then Min asked the officers to hide the truth," the ad's narrator says over footage of Min's arrest, with Min asking a police officer "there's no way to not release this?"

"Trust Dave Min," the ad says. "Not on your life."

Other UDP ads attacked Min for taking corporate PAC money and accepting donations from "special interests and drug companies before voting against lowering prescription costs" as well as "advising a right-wing group that supported the overturning of Roe v. Wade" when "women's rights were under assault."

The attacks against Min bring UDP's tactics under renewed scrutiny once again after its methods two years ago earned derision from much of the Democratic base – particularly since the super PAC's involvement in Democratic primaries was largely bankrolled by Republican megadonors.

UDP's anti-Min push, however, brings into question UDP's evolving "pro-Israel" litmus test for candidates and what sort of policies cross the line for the organization following October 7.

"Despite State Sen. Min's support of Israel, and a broad coalition of endorsements from the Jewish community, a number of Republican donors at AIPAC are upset that he has called for Bibi Netanyahu to be held accountable for the security failures on Oct. 7 and Netanyahu's failure of leadership during this crisis," Min campaign manager Dan Driscoll said in a statement reported by various media outlets.

"Sen. Min does not believe in the annexation of West Bank settlements. He had hoped that a constructive dialogue could be had. It appears they disagreed," he added.

Beyond this, Min has earned endorsements from AIPAC-aligned lawmakers like Reps. Grace Meng and Kevin Mullin (for whom UDP spent nearly $589,000 in support last election).

Meng, a Democrat from New York, publicly criticized a UDP anti-Min mailer, accusing the Super PAC of trafficking in anti-Asian tropes.

"Political attacks are expected in any campaign. Attacks literally coloring an Asian American candidate in yellow is highly insensitive at best. Questioning an Asian candidate's trustworthiness is a tired and old trope," she posted alongside an image of the mailer, reaffirming her endorsement of Min.

Meng later told Politico that she was attempting to broker a peace between AIPAC and Min, saying "we don't really know why they're going after him, and we're trying to find out. He has had a pro-Israel record, so we're trying to find out why they're going after one of the Asian community's top-priority candidates."

AIPAC and UDP did not respond to a request for comment on Meng's allegations that the ads flirt with anti-Asian racism nor her efforts to get UDP to tone down its attacks.

When asked why UDP is targeting Min and focusing on his arrest rather than his Israel positions, a spokesperson said "voters in this California district deserve to know."

Where is J Street?

Min has earned other key endorsements, including from Porter herself as well as the Los Angeles Times and local Jewish politicians like fellow state Sen. Scott Wiener and California State Assembly member Jesse Gabriel.

The rest of the pro-Israel establishment, meanwhile, has rallied strongly behind Weiss, including organizations like Democratic Majority for Israel. While UDP has spent most of its money attacking Min, it has taken out at least $104,000 in pro-Weiss ads.

Weiss has been further buoyed by at least $1 million from EMILYs List, the organization dedicated to electing Democratic pro-choice women to office. UDP and EMILYs List have established a relationship over the past two election cycles, with EMILYs List making a $4,000 in-kind donation for research and UDP giving the group's "Women Vote" independent expenditure arm $200,000 in August.

AIPAC and UDP did not respond to comment about its relationship with EMILYs List and its potential coordination on this as well as other races.

"The U.S. is a leader on the international stage to help promote democracies across the globe. We have a responsibility to promote peace, uphold international law and honor our alliances. We must continue to stand by our strategic partners, including Ukraine and Israel, to protect democracies across the world and to fight against tyranny and terrorism," Weiss told the Orange County Register.

"Congress and the U.S. government broadly have a responsibility to promote peace around the world while also holding our partners accountable to limit civilian casualties and allow for the flow of humanitarian aid to affected areas," she added, staking out positions that are ostensibly more sufficiently pro-Israel than Min's, which are in lockstep with the majority of the Democratic Party.

One organization that notably hasn't endorsed either Min or Weiss is J Street, which confirmed it has communicated with both candidates.

The financially draining campaign has led both Weiss and Min to spend much more than they have raised ahead of the primary, putting the eventual winner at a financial disadvantage against likely Republican opponent Scott Baugh in the general election.

The race portends significant UDP spending in the coming months in other primary races, particularly those of Reps. Jamaal Bowman, Cori Bush and Summer Lee but perhaps others as well.

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